Lesson 12: Active Reading: Asking Questions and Annotating

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 2: Critical Reading

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 1.4: Using Questions to Be an Active Reader; 1.5: Annotating a Text; 1.5.1: Accessible Version of Annotation Example on 1.5.

In this lesson

Reading is not a passive process. In this lesson you will retell a report after a timed reading, ask questions before, during and after reading, study a model annotation, and annotate a short research article. These strategies help you understand difficult academic texts and save time later: when you write an essay or prepare for a test, your notes are already on the page.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Read quickly for the overall meaning and retell it in your own words.
- Ask questions before, during and after reading, including fact-based and open-ended WH-questions.
- Explain what each note in a model annotation does.
- Annotate an academic article with predictions, questions, key points, connections and unclear words.
- Evaluate which annotation strategies work best for you.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
active reading	reading while you question, predict and connect the text to what you know	As good readers, we are constantly connecting our own knowledge to the text.
annotate / annotation	write notes while you read, usually on the text itself / those notes	Annotating makes our thinking visible.
margin	the empty space beside the text on a page	Write questions in the margins where answers can be found.
WH-question (fact-based / open-ended)	a question with who, what, when, where, why or how; a fact-based one has an answer in the text, an open-ended one asks for reasons or opinions	"How many undocumented immigrants live in the U.S.?" / "Why do you think that the number … has declined since 2007?"
credentials	a person's background and qualifications	Who is the author? What are their credentials?

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
bias	a strong opinion that makes it hard to be objective	Do I have any biases about the topic?
author's purpose	the reason for writing: to inform, persuade or entertain (often more than one)	What seems to be the author's purpose?
concession	a point where a writer admits a limit or a point against their own position	[Yes, it is a concession.]
simile	a comparison that uses like or as	"Not having a driver's license is like not having feet."
empirical study	research based on observation and data	Most empirical studies cannot separate undocumented immigrants from the total immigrant population.

Rules and explanations

Reading is an active process

- Active readers connect the text to what they know. Besides prereading and KWL+ (Lesson 11), they skip confusing parts and return to them later, take notes on the main points of each section, read some parts quickly and some slowly, read again, and tell someone else what they understand.
- Reading quickly with a timer makes you search for the overall meaning, without stopping to look up words or getting caught in small details. Studying alone, tell your tutor what you understood, or say it aloud and record yourself.

Asking questions before, during and after reading

Questions are like a conversation with the writer: What do you mean here? Who is involved? Why is this important? How did you arrive at that conclusion? As some questions are answered, new ones arise. (Table 1.4.1 in the material, arranged by column.)

Before reading	During reading	After reading
Why am I reading this? What type of text is it (article, research paper, blog, TED talk)?	What key terms does the author define or repeat?	What did I learn? Was anything unclear? (Reread those parts.)
Who is the author, with what credentials? Which publication? When?	What is the author's purpose (inform, persuade, entertain)? Who is the audience?	Did I find what I needed?
What do the title, headings and graphic aids tell me? What do I know and feel about the topic? Do I have biases?	What are the key points or thesis? What evidence supports them? What does the author mean by X?	Was the style persuasive? Do I agree? How does it compare with other texts? What do I want to investigate more?

Annotating

- Annotation means writing notes while you read. Highlighting alone is passive; notes make you engage with the text, read more closely and remember more. Later you can use your annotations instead of rereading everything. Annotations are personal: each reader brings their own ideas and background.
- Active readers annotate to: make predictions; ask questions and look for answers; visualize (picture it, or draw a diagram); show agreement or disagreement; identify problems and/or solutions; make connections (to themselves, other texts, the world); mark key points; summarize key points or sections; note information that shocks, surprises or challenges them; identify unfamiliar vocabulary or unclear parts.
- Techniques: symbols, key words and short summaries in the margin; circled definitions; numbered steps; arrows between related ideas.
- In the model (section 1.5.1), **bold** shows the words the reader marked and [brackets] show the reader's notes.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - In English WH-questions, put the auxiliary verb before the subject: "Why has the number declined?" (not "Why the number has declined?"). When there is no other auxiliary, add do, does or did: "Where do most immigrants come from?"

Practice

Exercise 1. Tell someone what you understood. Use the UNICEF report "A Child is a Child: Protecting Children on the Move from Violence, Abuse and Exploitation" in the lesson material.

1. Set a timer for 2 minutes and read as much as you can.
2. Tell your tutor (or say aloud) what you understood, in your own words.
3. Set the timer for 2 minutes again and read from the top. Tell your tutor again.
4. Read the whole report without a timer and tell your tutor what you learned.
5. Did this help you understand the report?

Exercise 2. Questions before, during and after reading. Read "Changes in U.S. Immigration Patterns and Attitudes" in the lesson material.

1. Before reading: What type of text is it, and where is it from? (Look at the heading and the Works Cited.) What do you think it will teach you?
2. During reading: Write at least three WH-questions. Make at least one fact-based and one open-ended.
3. Answer your fact-based questions from the text.
4. After reading: Was anything unclear?

Exercise 3. Study a model annotation. Read the editorial "A Win for Undocumented Immigrants is a Win for All" by Tram Nguyen first. Then read the annotated version (section 1.5.1). What does each note do? Use the list of purposes in "Annotating" above; more than one purpose can fit.

1. [Will look for exactly how the new law helps everyone and mark with *]
2. [the law changed]
3. [How are these different from a driver's license?]
4. [What does "previously undocumented" mean? Does the driver's license count as a document?]
5. [great simile]
6. [* how the new law helps everyone]
7. [Maybe this signals a concession?] ... [Yes, it is a concession.]
8. [Privilege cards are not enough. I wonder how many eligible people will not get one for fear of being identifiable.]
9. [What does privacy mean in this context? Why did Nguyen emphasize this here?]
10. What else would you add? Write two notes of your own.

Exercise 4. Annotate an article. Use the article "Undocumented Immigrants May Actually Make American Communities Safer – Not More Dangerous – New Study Finds" by Robert M. Adelman and Lesley Reid (The Conversation, 2020) in the lesson material.

1. Get an overview first with active reading strategies (title, headings, first and last parts).
2. Annotate as you read. Write at least eight notes of at least five different kinds.

Exercise 5. Reflect on your annotations. What worked well? What was confusing? Which kinds of annotation did you use most? Which did you not try, and why? What will you do differently next time? (Discuss with your tutor instead of a group.)

Speak with your tutor

- "I read the UNICEF report for two minutes. Here is what I understood: [say it]. Ask me two questions about what I missed."
- "Here are my WH-questions about 'Changes in U.S. Immigration Patterns and Attitudes': [paste]. Is the word order correct? Which are fact-based and which are open-ended?"
- "Here are my annotations on the Adelman and Reid article: [paste]. Which purposes from the list did I use? Which did I miss?"
- "Ask me the after-reading questions about the Nguyen editorial: Did I find the author's style persuasive? Do I agree? Make me give reasons."

Read aloud

In WH-questions, the voice usually falls at the end; in yes/no questions, it usually rises.

1. Reading is not a passive process.
2. When we ask questions, it is as though we are having a conversation with the writer.
3. Why do you think that the number of undocumented immigrants has declined since 2007? (voice falls)
4. How are these different from a driver's license? (voice falls)

5. Does the driver's license count as a document? (voice rises)
6. Not having a driver's license is like not having feet. Being able to drive would be like having wings.
7. Word stress: AN·no·tate, an·no·TA·tion, cre·DEN·tials, con·CES·sion, em·PIR·i·cal, xen·o·PHO·bi·a.

Writing task

An active reading log. Choose one text:

- the Adelman and Reid article (if you did not annotate all of it in Exercise 4);
- a section of a PSYC 110 lecture transcript, for example Lecture 17, Chapter 7, "The Greater Mystery of Dreams";
- a section of the free OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e* (https://openstax.org/details/books/psychology-2e), for example on sleep or memory.

Write:

1. Three questions you asked before reading.
2. Six of your annotations: copy the words you marked and your note, as in the model.
3. A paragraph of 120-160 words that answers the after-reading questions: What did I learn? What was unclear? Do I agree? What do I want to investigate more?

Checklist:

- Your before-reading questions cover purpose, type of text and author.
- Your annotations include at least four different purposes (for example a prediction, a question, a key point, a connection).
- At least one note marks an unclear word or part, and you checked it after reading.
- Your WH-questions have correct word order (auxiliary before subject).
- Your paragraph gives reasons for your opinion, not only "I agree".

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 (example answer) Millions of children cross borders to escape violence, conflict, disaster or poverty, and many travel alone. Because there are few legal ways to move, they take dangerous routes and pay smugglers, and weak protection leaves them open to abuse and exploitation by traffickers. Details to check: 92 per cent of children who reached Italy across the Central Mediterranean in 2016 and early 2017 were unaccompanied (alone); at least 300,000 unaccompanied and separated children were registered in 2015-2016, almost five times as many as in 2010-2011 (66,000); Europol estimates that 20 per cent of suspected smugglers have ties to human trafficking.

Exercise 2

1. A textbook passage (sociology), adapted from Lumen Learning, *Introduction to Sociology*. Its purpose is mainly to inform. (example answer) It will teach me how immigration to the U.S. has changed.
2. (example answer) Fact-based: How many immigrants lived in the U.S. in 2018? Where did most immigrants come from in 1960? How many undocumented immigrants live in the U.S.? Open-ended: Why did immigration from Europe and Canada decline from the 1970s?
3. In 2018, over 44.8 million (more than four times the 9.7 million of 1960). In 1960, the vast majority came from Europe and Canada; this changed in the 1970s. About 10.5 million are undocumented, down from a peak of 12.2 million in 2007 (73% of immigrants lived in the U.S. legally in 2018).
4. (example answer) The text does not say why the number of undocumented immigrants fell, or which survey it means. Two sentences also contain errors: "the source countries of immigrants has changed" (it should be "have") and "a large shift in during the 1970s" (delete "in").

Exercise 3

1. Makes a prediction from the title and sets a question to look for answers; it creates a symbol (*) to mark them.
2. Summarizes a key point.
3. Asks a question about a key term.
4. Identifies an unclear phrase and asks questions about it.
5. Responds to the writer's wording: the reader admires the comparison "Being able to drive would be like having wings."
6. Finds an answer to the question in note 1 and marks it with *: safer streets and more money staying in the state.
7. Makes a prediction from the signal word "But", then checks it: the writer admits that privilege cards are not the same as driver's licenses.
8. Identifies a problem (the cards may identify people as undocumented), gives the reader's opinion, and asks a question ("I wonder ...").
9. Asks about the meaning of a word in context and about the writer's purpose.

10. (example answer) Circle "xenophobia" [unfamiliar word: check it; it means fear or dislike of people from other countries]. Mark the author's role, co-executive director of New Virginia Majority [her organization fought for this law, so her purpose is to persuade].

Exercise 4 (example answer)

- "The big idea" [main idea: no rise in violent crime, maybe less property crime].
- "baselessly blamed" [strong words: the authors disagree with this claim].
- "most empirical studies cannot separate undocumented immigrants from the total immigrant population" [the problem with earlier research].
- "154 metropolitan areas", "FBI's Uniform Crime Report" [evidence: where the data came from].
- "regression analysis" [unclear term: look it up; psychology also uses statistics like this].
- "as the size of the undocumented population increases, the property crime rate decreases" [key finding; draw an arrow back to "The big idea"].
- "What still isn't known" [limits: broad patterns only, not specific cities; does not explain why].

Exercise 5 (example answer) Questions and key points were easy to write. I did not visualize or make connections, because I was focused on understanding the facts. Next time I will connect the article to what I know about research methods from PSYC 110.

My notes